



THE MALAYSIAN PROVINCE OF SARAWAK on northwest Borneo

IBAN

PEOPLE OF THE LONGHOUSES

Island is a maze of endless rivers making their way through dense, steamy rain forests. It is here that the Iban people live, forming

Longhouses

The Iban live in longhouses, which are at the very center of communal life in Sarawak. Most longhouses are riverside dwellings and are therefore built on stilts to prevent flooding. The entire community lives under one roof.

An Iban bride wears a full silver headdress.



VILLAGE LIFE

The longhouses are divided into apartments and when a new couple is married, often they will simply add another building to the end of the house. Some longhouses have hundreds of rooms under one roof. A long communal balcony runs along the side of the house with the doors to the apartments along it.



CARVING AND WEAVING

The Iban people learn to weave and carve from an early age. The men carve and the women weave; the gifted continue all their lives and are highly valued. They believe the objects they make protect them from evil spirits.

The agom is a carved wooden figure that is placed on the pathways to rice fields to protect the crop.



JEWELRY

Large earrings and gold teeth show that a girl comes from a well-to-do family. The teeth are sometimes inlaid with precious stones. Heavy earrings create large, elongated earlobes.

